

Solutions Engineer Hiring Assignment

A hands-on exercise in technical storytelling, data modeling, and search relevance — built around a real prospect scenario.

This is the hiring assignment for the Solutions Engineering team at Algolia.

The goal of this exercise is to test your ability to understand technical concepts, explain them clearly, manipulate data, and build demos (with your preferred tooling). We expect strong SEs to use the tools available to them to move faster, explore ideas, and deliver better outcomes for prospects.

WHAT WE CARE ABOUT

- ☒ Understand Algolia's core technical concepts
- ☒ Transform messy customer data into a useful search index
- ☒ Design a relevant and compelling search and discovery experience
- ☒ Make thoughtful architecture and implementation decisions
- ☒ Evaluate search quality and tune configuration accordingly
- ☒ Communicate your choices clearly to both technical and non-technical audiences

AI tools are welcome. Use them to help write code, manipulate data, generate UI ideas, debug, or accelerate implementation — just be ready to explain the concepts, architecture, trade-offs, and decisions behind what you built.

Prospect Context: Account Executive Discovery Notes

Refer to [prospect-context.md](#) for the full discovery notes.

Communication Project Instructions

Review the example customer questions in [customer-questions.md](#) and answer them using the Algolia documentation.

Include your answers in your repository — a [.txt](#), [.md](#), or similar plain-text format is fine.

We are evaluating how clearly you can explain technical topics to a customer. Strong answers should be accurate, concise, and adapted to the customer's likely level of understanding.

Technical & UX Project Instructions

Our sales team has recently been contacted by **OpenTable**. As a Solutions Engineer, your task is to build a small interactive prototype using the provided restaurant dataset. Your demo should highlight the value of a great search and discovery experience, using the discovery notes as your guide.

This is **not** a pixel-perfect implementation exercise. The provided mock-up represents OpenTable's current experience — context on what they have today, not a target to recreate. The prospect wants something **better**: a more modern, useful, and compelling search and discovery experience. Show us how you'd bring a prospect a vision, not just a functional search box.

Important: Do not fork this repository to create your assignment. Create your own private or public repository for your work and send the link when you submit.

WHAT YOU SHOULD BUILD

Project repository: <https://github.com/algolia/solutions-hiring-assignment/tree/master>

Download the [project files](#), then build a working restaurant discovery demo that includes:

- ☒ An Algolia index populated with the provided restaurant data
- ☒ A data preparation process that combines and cleans the provided files
- ☒ A search interface that lets users find restaurants through text search
- ☒ Relevant filtering or refinement, including cuisine type
- ☒ Location-aware ranking, or a thoughtful fallback if browser geolocation is unavailable
- ☒ Search configuration that you have tested and tuned based on the dataset
- ☒ A UX that shows how OpenTable's search and discovery could be improved for both known-item search and open-ended discovery

Choose the implementation approach that best demonstrates your understanding of Algolia and your ability to deliver value quickly.

Data Requirements

The dataset is available in the `./resources/dataset` folder.

<code>restaurants_list.json</code>	~5,000 restaurants
<code>restaurants_info.csv</code>	Additional information about those restaurants

Because the data is split across files, you will need to manipulate and combine them before indexing. Your indexed records should include the information needed to support the search experience, including cuisine type.

INCLUDE IN YOUR REPOSITORY

- ☒ How the files were joined
- ☒ What transformations or cleanup you performed
- ☒ Which attributes you indexed
- ☒ Which attributes you made searchable, facetable, or ranking-related
- ☒ Any assumptions you made about the data

Feel free to enrich the data with any additional information useful for discovery purposes.

Search & Relevance Requirements

Do not stop once search technically works. Test it as if you were preparing for a customer meeting — try representative searches and refinements, inspect the results, and adjust the index configuration where needed.

Your submission should show evidence that you considered:

- [Searchable attributes](#)
- [Ranking & custom ranking](#)
- [Facets & filters](#)
- [Geo-search](#)
- [Typo tolerance](#)
- [Result ordering](#)

... and how the experience should behave when the query is broad, specific, misspelled, ambiguous, location-sensitive, or empty.

You do not need a perfect configuration — we want to see that you can reason about search quality, test your assumptions, and improve the experience iteratively.

Deliverables

- ☒ A link to the live demo (GitHub Pages, Vercel, Netlify, or similar)
- ☒ A link to your Git repository
- ☒ Your answers to the communication project questions
- ☒ A short explanation of your approach

What Happens Next

Refer to [interview-next-steps.md](#) for details on the process ahead.